overwhelmed the enemy with surprise, and our soldiers achieved a glorious victory. Such attacks tilted the scale irrevocably in our favour, and heralded the beginning of the end of Operation Vijay.

- By 10 July 1999, through a series of pincer movements, most of the Pakistani-held positions were in the process of being isolated and their logistics chain severely disrupted. The ration stocks at most of the captured localities were at precarious levels. There was little or no medical cover at most locations. It must be appreciated that to evacuate one casualty in such altitudes two teams of four soldiers each would be required. Where would the manpower come from? Either the post would have to be abandoned or else the wounded soldier left to die. In some positions there was an acute shortage of drinking water too. The Indian Army was closing in on all positions. The Mashko valley was addressed in the later phases as it was on a flank, but it was just a matter of a few more weeks. The remainder of the positions held by the demotivated and demoralized Pakistani NLI and other regular army soldiers were falling like nine pins. In the MO operations room it was a welcome sign to see the red pins (indicating positions held by Pakistani troops) being replaced by blue at a faster pace every day. The claims made by General Musharraf that the remaining Pakistani positions could have held out, were utopian, wishful and unrealistic.
- The effective use of artillery and the air force gave us an unbeatable edge over the Pakistanis. Most of the attacks were launched with overwhelming fire support of over one hundred guns, mortars and multi-barrel rocket launchers. Thousands of shells, bombs and rockets carrying many tons of TNT breaking into warped shrapnels of metal, wreaked havoc on the enemy. We were aware that hitting the targets in such a difficult and rocky terrain with knife-edged ridges was very difficult, yet the boom of the guns and sound of the blasts reverberating in the mountains played on the minds of the soldiers of both sides – positive and morale-boosting in our case, and demoralizing for the Pakistani soldiers. It is estimated that a large percentage of Pakistani